Backward Compatibility

Cisco regularly updates our APIs to provide new or enhanced functionality. Our goal is to keep our API changes backward-compatible within the same API version (see API Versions) so that you don't have to update your code whenever we make these changes.

Backward-compatible changes for our SOAP and REST APIs include:

- Adding new APIs
- Adding optional API request parameters
- Adding new fields to existing API responses
- Adding new values to existing API parameters that have enumerated sets of values
- Adding HTTP response headers or adding values to existing response headers

Backward-compatible changes for our push APIs include:

- Adding new Push API event types
- Adding HTTP POST form parameters
- Adding new fields to the “data” XML content
- Adding new values to existing API parameters that have enumerated sets of values
- Adding HTTP request headers or adding values to existing request headers

You should write your API clients (for SOAP and REST APIs) and push receivers (for push APIs) with the expectation that these API changes will happen, so that they can handle such changes gracefully. For example, do not hard-code to a fixed set of API response fields, since new response fields may be added in the future; instead, look for only the fields that you are interested in, and ignore any other fields.

While Cisco strives to ensure that the majority of API changes are backward-compatible, there are times when incompatible changes need to be made. Backward-incompatible changes include:

- Removing or renaming an API, request parameter, response field, or enum value
- Changing the visible behavior of existing APIs

Through the Release Notes, Cisco will provide at least six months' notice before backward-incompatible changes go into effect. This notice will include specific information about the change along with instructions for upgrading your code without service disruption.

API Versions

Every API function includes a version number that identifies the API structure and behavior. Cisco increments this version number under the following circumstances:

- The API receives a backward-incompatible change AND
- The previous version of the API continues to be supported.

Refer to the detailed documentation to learn more about version numbers for each type of API.

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